Promises

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/45644392.

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General Audiences

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by cabbageboy

Summary

Adora never got to deal with her anger issues.

Now she's in therapy for them.

A small conversation between Catra and Adora about that night on Darla

Notes

Adora has some anger issues that need to be addressed, and its most evident when they're on Darla after Save the Cat.

Adora wasn’t sure how long she’d been laying awake.

The sun had set long ago, with Catra laying her head on Adora's chest and the two of them snuggled close. One of the moons began to sink below the horizon, darkening the whispering woods and the surrounding land as much as it could.

But even then, as night fell, Adora was restless. So much so that, though she tried to be still, it still awakened her sleeping partner.

“What's wrong?” Catra asks. It’s simple. Because she knows Adora would be dead asleep if not for those thoughts racing through her head.

“Sorry, did I wake you?” Adora says, kissing the top of Catra’s head as she stretches and yawns.

“Only by your lack of snoring.”

“I don’t snore!”

“Psh, you snore *so loud,* princess,” Catra mumbles.

They both giggle a little bit and Adora feels lighter. But not light enough to fall asleep and certainly not light enough to let it go.

“We can talk about it tomorrow. You can go back to sleep,” Adora tries, but Catra has already rolled more on top of her, purring into her neck. Adora’s hands move with her as the body on top of hers settles between her legs.

Catra looks up.

“Nope, it's bothering you now and I’m not getting back to sleep unless you get to sleep, so what is it?”

Adora is silent for a moment, not really sure where to start. She’s upset about it, and maybe that meant it wasn’t the right time to

talk, because lord knows what she'd done when she was upset before.

But the other part of her, the part that desperately wanted to get it over with, get it out in the open so she could start to heal, so Catra could start to heal from it too, was overpowering.

She stares at the ceiling for a long time, trailing fingers up and down Catra's back. The warmth of the line of fur that was thicker at her spine tickles Adora's fingers and palm, and she presses harder when Catra starts to nuzzle into her neck more. The other hand cups Catra's cheek gently, holding her close and burying her nose into Catra's hair.

It's peaceful, just like it was every night since the war ended. The iridescent, opalescent sheen of magic that covered every surface, that tinted the air with glowing speckles of the pure magic of Etheria, glowed comfortingly at night. It was beautiful, made Etheria and everything in it look just as beautiful as it was always meant to. A large branch broke its way through the bedroom from the tree that had grown up the side of the castle, and it ran through the center of the room at the ceiling, several feet over the bed. Catra had scared her, pouncing on her from the obscured vantage point more than once, but it was a nice place for them to hang a hammock from and snuggle during the day. At night they looked up at the trailing vines that spread over the ceiling, flowering in some places closer to the humidity of the waterfall or the light of the balcony.

The magic, the flora that had spread over structures the world over, had been an unpleasant topic to those that were left homeless by the overgrowth, but they were working on a reconstruction plan that would bring homes to those that had lost theirs during the war and rebuilding the kingdoms around the newfound foliage.

Brightmoon castle had been particularly affected, similarly to the Fright Zone. The outside was covered in a splotchy lair of moss and flowers, vines that wound their way up the spiraling towers

and the great wings that unfolded to hold the runestone. Trees from the gardens that had been carefully pruned over the years grew out of control, up the side of the castle and puncturing the structure in gigantic open wounds where branches grew through the walls.

It was how Adora fell asleep at night, cuddled up with Catra on her chest, tracing the vines that worked their way around the room with her eyes until she lost track of them and fell asleep. But tonight that hadn't happened, and it was because of something she did, something she regretted.

Something Catra deserves an apology for.

"Not to rush you or anything but if you keep that up I'm going to fall asleep and I know you have something you need to talk about," Catra mumbles, breathing deeply the scent of bergamot and lavender oil that Adora rubbed on her wrists and neck, a sleep remedy the sorcerers had recommended when she couldn't fall asleep on her own during the war. Not that it worked most of the time. But the first time she tried it after the war and walked out of the bathroom smelling that unique spiced floral combination, Catra had slept deeper than Adora ever remembered her being able to.

Needless to say, she kept wearing the oils on her skin every night, and eventually it did help her sleep. Just not tonight.

Adora takes a deep breath, holds it for a few seconds, and exhales, willing her heart rate to calm.

"I will, I just… I don't want to bring up something that will upset you and that will bring a bad… energy to our relationship. But at the same time it's a thing that has already happened and I shouldn't be so worried about it when I know you'll understand-"

"Babe, if it's already happened I've already forgiven you for it. I did the second you told me you loved me, because I knew that anything that happened between us during the war was what we

had to do to survive. And I know you don't hold what I had to do during the war against me either. So just… you can tell me anything and I'll listen. Then we can get back to bed once you have it off of your chest."

"I'm sorry." It comes out meek, the softness and gentleness that Catra always expected during their early morning, late night talks.

But she wanted answers, wanted to know what Adora could possibly be apologizing for when they already talked about the war and their parts in it and how sorry they were to have lost each other, their regrets and everything they did wrong that kept them apart.

"Sorry for…?" Catra says, leaning up so her eyes are fixed on Adora.

"I'm sorry for…. How *rough* I always was with you when you needed someone to be gentle. I'm sorry for how I let my anger get the better of me so many times and I took it out on you when you didn't deserve it. I'm sorry for *throwing you off of the bed* on Darla when I had just gotten you back, when I had just defied the laws of the universe and brought you back from what I thought was too far dead to ever come back. I'm sorry for all the times I did something like that when we were growing up. I just… I'm sorry that I ever let my anger take over and that I reacted with such violence toward you," Adora rushes out.

Part of her was worried she wouldn't be able to say all of it without crying, which wouldn't be productive when she was trying to apologize for something that she did. Another part of her was worried that Catra would counter, interrupt and speak affirmation when Adora didn't think she wanted it during this conversation.

There was a lot she was apologizing for, after all. A lifetime's worth of anger issues expressed in an unhealthy manner were still building up and now that she had realized it, had it brought to the

forefront of her mind, she was even more convinced she had to clear the air with Catra about it.

"Babe…" Catra sighs, the hand that had been brushing gently against Adora's bare shoulder now came up to run the thumb along her jawline, tilting her face toward Catra.

"I know all of that. I know you're sorry, and you're different now. Growing up the way we did… It is understandable not to be a particularly well adjusted person. You dealt with your anger the only way it seemed like we were allowed to."

Adora shakes her head.

"But that was when I was with the Horde. I had three *years* of completely cognizant adulthood to learn how to deal with it and I still *threw you off of the bed* on Darla like I didn't even care about you when you were all I cared about at that moment."

Catra sighs, nodding.

"I'm not saying it's okay, or that I would accept that kind of treatment from you now in our relationship. I am just saying that I understand, and that I forgive you. Isn't that enough? To know that I don't hold it against you?"

There's quiet for a moment while Adora thinks of how to say this next part.

"I started seeing someone…" Adora whispers.

Catra's heart drops.

"W-What?"

Adora's eyes widen.

"About my anger issues! A therapist! The one Perfuma talks to. I started talking to her every week. I wanted to… to finally tell you. Because I know it doesn't make me weak to need help and I want

you to know about everything in my life, all of the messy parts that make me who I am… I saved the universe after all. I guess I deserve a little help when I need it. She told me that. Not just because I am She-ra, but because I am Adora. And Adora deserves it too."

Catra hums.

"Well then, that is something that she and I agree on. You deserve help, Adora. When you think you need it and when you don't. You deserve all that is good in the world. And not just because you saved Etheria. You deserve it because you're Adora, because you're you."

They lay there for a long time, Adora caressing Catra's back and Catra rubbing soothing circles with her thumb on Adora's jawline.

"Not to bring things up again if you were done talking about it but…. Why are we not asleep?" Catra asks

"How did you feel?"

"How did I feel when…..?"

"How did you feel on Darla, when I threw you off of the bed, when I let my anger get the better of me and I reacted that way. I know that there were other times but I can't think of anything as ridiculous as the way I treated you then. I want to know how you felt when I did that."

Catra sighs. If there was one thing she didn't want is to make Adora feel worse than she clearly already felt about it. But honesty was what their relationship needed, no matter how much it hurt.

"To be honest I don't think I recognized it as your anger. I was upset that it happened but I was also just upset at the conversation. I thought you hated me, that you saved me because you're Adora and that's just what you do. You save people that don't deserve it."

Adora feels her mouth click shut at the notion that Catra, being Adora's dearest friend, saving Glimmer, and giving the middle finger to Prime, wouldn't deserve to be saved. Because that wasn't the point of the conversation and it would only detract from where they were headed with it.

"And I wanted to be out of that room and as far away from the conflict between us as possible. I was offended that you did that, but I don't think I recognized it as your anger. I think I just recognized it as you… as the way we used to be with each other. And it isn't right that we were that way with each other but we didn't know anything different growing up."

Adora's shoulders deflate.

"You didn't even ask me to come after you."

"Hmm?" Catra tilts her head. She knows that, but it didn't mean she deserved to be saved any less and it didn't mean she hated Adora for it.

"I did it because I wanted to, because I needed you back. But I blamed you. When they came after us afterward, I said 'Catra is ruining our lives' and 'Catra is being a brat' even though you didn't ask to be saved, you asked me to stay away. And it was so wrong of me to be so mad at you when you didn't do anything wrong, when you told me to stay away so that they wouldn't come after us. It was so, so fucking wrong of me Catra and I just… I don't want you to say you forgive me, because I don't have a handle on all the things that make me angry and all the ways I show that anger, but I want you to know that I am trying. That I know you weren't at fault for anything that happened then and that I am so damn embarrassed that I acted that way toward you," Adora says with conviction.

And Catra knows it, understands it.

"But I want you to promise me something in return," Adora asks.

Catra nods.

“Yeah?"

“I want you to promise me that you won’t take it. That you won’t accept that kind of treatment, especially now that we are in a relationship. I want you to promise me that you won’t let me mistreat you, because of my anger or otherwise.”

Or otherwise.

And Catra starts to realize that this conversation isn't all it seems.

“Dor, what brought this on? Because I forgave you for all of that a long time ago. What made you start seeing someone for it?” Catra asks.

Adora sighs.

“Glimmer. She started talking about how once her and Bow were married they would have to… produce an heir to the throne… not that she said it like that but she implied it. And I couldn’t stand the thought of being around someone as vulnerable as a child when I used to be so angry that I acted with violence toward the person I love the most.”

After all this time, Adora was so afraid of becoming like Shadow Weaver. Someone that mistreated people because she was angry. Someone that took that anger out on someone who couldn’t defend themself.

“‘Dor… You’re not *her* . You’ll never be *her.* And you’ll never treat me or a child the way she did. Ok?” Catra emphasizes her point with a nudge to Adora’s shoulder.

“I know. But I also know that I have the capacity for great anger, and that I never knew how to deal with it before. So promise me? Please?” Adora asks.

Adora would never ask for a promise if it didn't mean something, if it wasn't important. This thing they had was built on promises,

the promise that they'd stay together, the promise that they'd bring each other home, the promise that they loved each other.

They could stand to add a few more promises.

"I promise," Catra whispers, kissing the corner of Adora's mouth.

Adora rotates her head to kiss back, deeply, with all of the love she has and all of the love she can show. She kisses back like she can't live without Catra, like she would never do anything to hurt her. She kisses back like she can't fathom the thought of letting her anger take hold of her and affect their relationship.

She kisses back in a way that makes Catra understand she's serious.

And they both fall asleep knowing that no matter what, their relationship would flourish under this new promise.

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